Amilpasa "Caloy" Bandaying

Amilpasa "Caloy" Bandaying (born c. 1944) is a Moro leader, former Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF) cadre, military officer, and public servant from the Zamboanga area in the Philippines.

He is best known as one of the surviving members of the MNLF Top 90, the elite founding batch of MNLF guerrillas trained in Pangkor Laut Island, Malaysia in 1969.

Over the course of several decades, Bandaying moved from armed revolutionary to institutional builder, serving in military, legislative, and civic roles while staying committed to peace, indigenous peoples' rights, and an accurate telling of Bangsamoro history.

Contents

1 BACKGROUND AND EARLY LIFE
2 EDUCATION AND THE TURNING POINT
3 MNLF TOP 90 AND REVOLUTIONARY YEARS
4 MILITARY AND GOVERNMENT CAREER
5 MAJOR CONTRIBUTIONS
6 PERSONAL LIFE AND FAMILY
7 LEGACY AND SIGNIFICANCE
8 SEE ALSO

BACKGROUND AND EARLY LIFE

Caloy Bandaying grew up in the Zamboanga area during a period of deepening unrest across Mindanao.

He was born around the mid-1940s, with accounts placing his 81st birthday in late 2025.

The details of his exact birthplace and parents remain relatively private in public records, but his roots tie him firmly to Muslim Mindanao and its indigenous heritage.

He has long been recognized for his close ties to indigenous peoples (IPs) in and around Zamboanga City, including the Subanen, Sama, and related groups. That dual identity, as both a Moro leader and an advocate for IP communities, would shape much of his later public work.

Amilpasa "Caloy" Bandaying

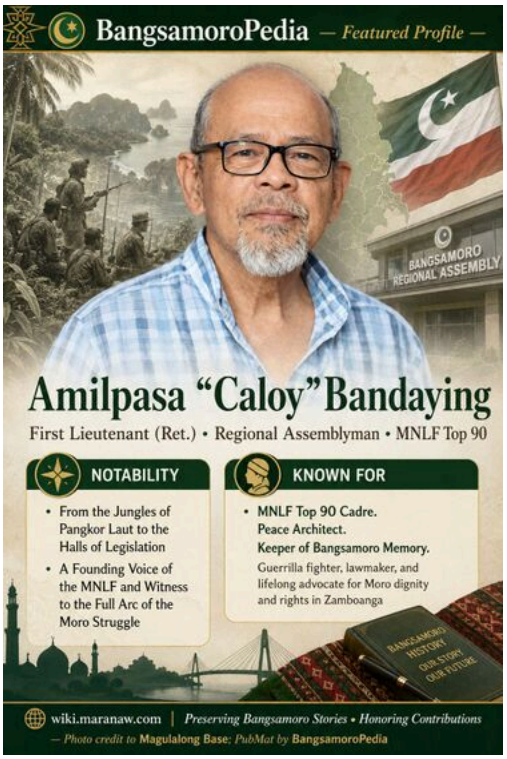


Photo: [To be added]

Born	c. 1944Template:Cn
Birthplace	Zamboanga area, PhilippinesTemplate:Cn
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Moro (Muslim Mindanao)
Education	B.A. Political Science, Zamboanga A.E. Colleges (now Universidad de Zamboanga), 1967; Law studies, University of Manila and Ateneo Law School (did not complete)Template:Cn
Spouse	Kah Hadji Nene Bandaying
Military rank	First Lieutenant, Armed Forces of the Philippines
Known affiliations	Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF), SOUTHCOM, Regional Autonomous

EDUCATION AND THE TURNING POINT

Bandaying earned a Bachelor of Arts in Political Science from Zamboanga A.E. Colleges (now Universidad de Zamboanga) in 1967.

He then headed to Manila to study law, first at the University of Manila, where he was among the top students in his batch, before transferring to Ateneo Law School after one semester.

His legal career, however, never got off the ground.

The Jabidah Massacre of 1968 changed everything. Like many young Moro intellectuals of his generation, Bandaying was radicalized by the event. He left his law studies behind and joined the emerging Moro nationalist movement, a decision that would define the next several decades of his life.

MNLF TOP 90 AND REVOLUTIONARY YEARS

In 1969, Bandaying became part of the original Top 90, the founding batch of MNLF cadres who underwent guerrilla warfare training on Pangkor Laut Island in Malaysia.

This group formed the organizational backbone of the MNLF: its early command structure, its ideological core, and its leadership pool. Fellow members of this cohort include names central to Bangsamoro history, among them Nur Misuari, **Abul Khayr Alonto**, and **Jamil Lucman**.

Government Region IX (RAG-9)

Notability

Surviving member of the MNLF's legendary Top 90; intellectual cadre of the early Moro nationalist movement; Regional Assemblyman and peace advocate

Known For

MNLF Top 90 founding cadre; Zone III Propaganda and Intelligence Officer; Regional Assemblyman of RAG-9; contribution to the Organic Act for the ARMM (RA 6734); advocacy for indigenous peoples in Zamboanga City

Pull Quote

"Revolutions involve not just battlefield courage but the harder work of reconciliation, institution-building, and mentoring the next generation."

Within the organization, Bandaying served as Zone III Propaganda and Intelligence Officer in Zamboanga del Sur.

He has been consistent in interviews and public statements on one important point: the Top 90 did not formally surrender or seek amnesty. Government peace initiatives, particularly those led by **Rear Admiral Romulo Espaldon**, opened paths for reconciliation, but on terms that did not require the cadres to abandon their dignity or their identity as revolutionary fighters.

MILITARY AND GOVERNMENT CAREER

By 1974, Bandaying had entered the Officer Training program at Fort Bonifacio Army School Center.

He graduated at the top of his class, posting a general average of 89.51%.

Espaldon, recognizing his ability, brought him on as an aide and close staff officer, even as some within the military establishment remained skeptical about a man who had come out of the MNLF. Bandaying rose to the rank of First Lieutenant, took on sensitive roles within the Southern Command (SOUTHCOM), and served as military liaison to the Regional Autonomous Government, Region IX (RAG-9).

In 1979, he was appointed Secretary of the Admiral's Unified Staff Office.

His transition to civilian governance followed naturally. In 1982, he was appointed Regional Assemblyman of RAG-9 and elected Speaker Pro Tempore of that body.

Under President Corazon Aquino in 1987, he joined the Regional Consultative Commission, contributing to the drafting of the Organic Act for the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (Republic Act 6734).

He later served as City Hall Executive Assistant on Muslim Affairs in Zamboanga City, and remained active in advocacy work covering peace, good governance, and federalism.

MAJOR CONTRIBUTIONS

Bandaying's contributions have come through both direct action and careful reflection.

As one of the few surviving members of the Top 90, he is a primary witness to the MNLF's formative years, and has been consulted in academic research on Bangsamoro history, peace processes, and political transitions.

He has spoken publicly on topics including indigenous peoples' rights, national heroes, and the complexities of the Moro struggle, consistently emphasizing dignity, historical integrity, and the importance of truth.

He has also taken steps to correct the historical record where he felt it had been distorted. Bandaying has distanced himself from unauthorized online versions of texts attributed to him, including certain circulating versions of "The Bangsamoro Story," noting factual inaccuracies in those texts and working toward corrections. His own writings and oral accounts stress reconciliation, the difficulty of institution-building after conflict, and the need for inclusive development across Mindanao.

As a member of the Council of Elders and an IP leader, he has worked to preserve the customs and traditions of Muslim tribes and to support government programs for indigenous communities, while continuing to bridge divides between Moro groups and the wider population of Zamboanga.

PERSONAL LIFE AND FAMILY

Bandaying is married to Kah Hadji Nene Bandaying, who is frequently mentioned alongside him in tributes from friends and colleagues.

Those who know him personally describe him as kind, eloquent, and steadfast. He is a proud grandfather, including to healthy triplets, and his faith and commitment to community come through in both his public appearances and private life.

LEGACY AND SIGNIFICANCE

What makes Caloy Bandaying's story compelling is the arc of it: a young man radicalized by injustice who spent decades afterward building the institutions he once fought against from the outside.

He fought for Moro self-determination in his youth. Later, he invested those same energies into making autonomy actually work, through military service, legislation, local governance, and civil society engagement.

He represents a generation that navigated the turn from armed struggle to political participation, and did so without abandoning the principles that drove them to resistance in the first place.

In Zamboanga and in broader Bangsamoro discourse, he remains a respected voice on peace, indigenous rights, and historical accuracy. His story is a reminder that revolutions require not just courage on the battlefield but the much harder work of reconciliation, institution-building, and passing something meaningful on to the next generation.

As a surviving Top 90 member and Moro intellectual, Bandaying's legacy continues through consultations, advocacy, and a quiet but firm insistence on getting the historical record right.

SEE ALSO

- Moro National Liberation Front
- MNLF Top 90
- Jabidah Massacre
- Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Republic Act 6734
- Nur Misuari
- Bangsamoro History
- Regional Autonomous Government, Region IX

Editorial Notice: BangsamoroPedia is a curated knowledge archive. Its pages are maintained by the editorial administrator to help ensure historical accuracy. If you would like to suggest corrections, share sources, or contribute information, please message the administrator through the official Facebook page: **Notable Muslim Filipinos**.

Retrieved from "https://wiki.maranaw.com/index.php?title=Amilpasa_%22Caloy%22_Bandaying&oldid=2596"